who would be sitting beside you at breakfast the next morning, but the level of performance remained consistent.

The first Test was drawn in arctic temperatures in Dunedin, and we worked hard to win a closely contested second Test on a difficult pitch in Hamilton, where I scored an important 83 in our first innings and Vernon Philander continued his irrepressible form, taking a total of 10 wickets in the match.

In the third Test at the revered Basin Reserve in Wellington, we batted first, secured a 200-run first-innings lead and then scored briskly to leave enough time to dismiss the hosts and win the match. Traditionalist eyebrows were raised when I executed my first-ever reverse sweep off a fast bowler in a Test match, hitting a ball from Doug Bracewell over the head of gully away to the boundary at third man.

'That stroke doesn't belong in Test cricket,' someone wrote afterwards.

I disagreed. JP and I were going well, doing whatever we could to score as swiftly as possible to set up a winning position. In my mind, there are no such things as 'correct' strokes and 'incorrect' strokes; there is an infinite range of available strokes, each carrying different levels of risk and reward. The skill of any batsman lies in selecting the right stroke at the right moment. In this match at the Basin Reserve, the reverse sweep seemed the right stroke at the right moment – and, with respect, it did go for four.

Our plans were falling into place, and we may well have secured the win if we had held our catches, including one relatively straightforward chance that I dropped in the slips. Even though it was unbelievably cold, even though it was difficult to keep any kind of feeling in your fingers, even though many of us in the slip cordon were desperately hoping the ball would not come anywhere near us, we should have held our catches.

Kane Williamson scored a defiant century on the fifth day, providing an early indication of his potential to become one of the outstanding batsmen in world cricket, and helped his team hold out for the draw,